

Lesson plan

Slide;

1. NA
2. Consider question, take feedback
3. Learning journey
4. TEACHER TALK introduce lesson
5. TEACHER TALK share information and check understanding of terms
6. Share information, give out case studies from the Old Testament, one each. Students should read and then independently answer the questions in their books before they share with their team
7. Answers
8. Consider the similarities between the accounts, share answer
9. TEACHER TALK Move onto New Testament teachings and share some of the saying of Jesus
10. Set up task
11. Show video
12. Answer questions in books, share answers
13. TEACHER TALK introduce prosperity gospel preachers
14. Give out case studies, one each. Read and then students should discuss the questions with their partner
15. Possible answers
16. Draw table, discuss and compete with team
17. Share possible answers
18. Return to lesson question and answer

By the end of the lessons students need to know;

1. What the prosperity gospel is
2. The biblical basis for this including Abraham and Job
3. The biblical arguments against, including references to the teachings of Jesus
4. Arguments for and against the prosperity gospel

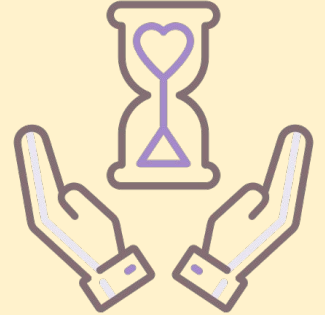
Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?



Which would you say is the better reward for living a good, kind and caring life?

- Long life
- Wisdom
- A large family
- Wealth
- Success

Why?



Lesson question; Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Topic question; Why don't all Christians express their religious tradition in the same way?

Unit 5 - Why don't all Christians express their religious tradition in the same way?

Core concepts



Belief



**Wisdom
and
authority**



Community

1. How diverse is Christianity in the USA?



1

2. What are the largest Christian groups in the USA?



2

4. What is the history and development of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter Day Saints?



4

6. Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?



6

3. What do fundamental Christians believe about creation?



3

7. How are religion and politics connected in the USA? *



7

5. What is the history and development of the Amish?



5

Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

In the Bible, God's blessing can be shown in different ways. Sometimes it appears as wisdom, long life, a large family, or success in work or wealth. Because of this, Christians have different ideas about what it means to be blessed by God.

Some Christians believe that God may reward faithfulness, kindness, and prayer with success or prosperity, and that wealth can be a sign of God's favour. Other Christians believe that the Bible teaches that wealth is not the most important thing, and that following Jesus might mean living simply, helping others, and avoiding the dangers of greed.

This means that even though Christians follow the same Bible, they can understand God's blessing in very different ways.



Lesson question; Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Topic question; Why don't all Christians express their religious tradition in the same way?



Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Today we are going to explore a specific example of this: the prosperity gospel, and why it is a controversial way of understanding God's blessing.

Prosperity means being successful and having enough money or resources to live comfortably and securely.

The **prosperity gospel** is a Christian teaching that God rewards faith, prayer, and generosity with prosperity, such as success, wealth, or good health.



Lesson question; Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

To understand why some Christians follow this idea we need to see what the Bible says.

First we are going to look at some examples where God rewards, or blesses, people. These are all from the Old Testament.

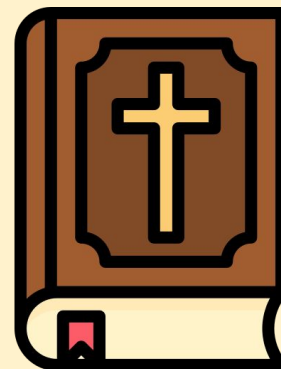
You have one of 4 examples; Abraham, Solomon, Job or Joseph.

First read what happens to them, then answer the following questions in your book;

1. **Why does God bless and reward them?**
2. **What blessings and rewards do they receive?**



Now share what you read and your answers with your team. What similarities or differences do you see?



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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Abraham

Solomon

Job

Joseph

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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Abraham

1. Why does God bless and reward them?
 - a. Because Abraham trusts God and obeys His promises.
2. What blessings and rewards do they receive?
 - a. He becomes very wealthy, receiving large flocks, servants, and more land than he promised that he would have. He has a great nation.

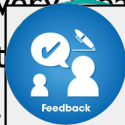
Solomon

1. Why does God bless and reward them?
 - a. Because Solomon asks God for wisdom to lead his people well instead of asking for riches or power.
2. What blessings and rewards do they receive?
 - a. He receives great wisdom, wealth, and a kingdom, and Israel becomes very prosperous.

Job

1. Why does God bless and reward them?
 - a. Because Job remains faithful and trusts God even after losing everything and suffering greatly.
2. What blessings and rewards do they receive?
 - a. God restores his wealth and gives him twice as much as he had before, along with a new family and a long life.

1. Why does God bless and reward them?
 - a. Because Joseph remains faithful and trusts God even when he is sold into slavery and faces difficult situations.
2. What blessings and rewards do they receive?
 - a. He becomes a powerful leader in Egypt, is put in charge of the country's resources, and gains authority, success, and prosperity.



They trust God, they stay faithful even when things are hard, and they act wisely or following God's commands.

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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Now we've looked at some examples of blessings in the Old Testament, let's look at the New Testament.

Jesus often taught about the dangers of wealth, which is why Christians sometimes disagree about this issue.

In the New Testament he says;

- “It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich person to enter the kingdom of God.”
- “Blessed are the poor.”



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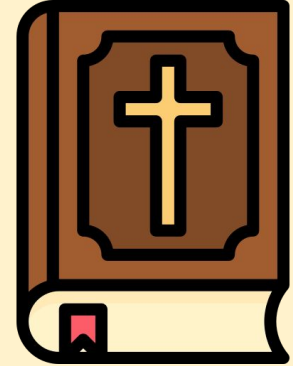
Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Jesus once told a parable about two men who lived very different lives.

A parable is a short story told to share a deeper lesson about God, right and wrong or how to live.

After watching the video answer;

1. What happened to the rich man?
2. What happened to Lazarus?
3. What might Jesus be teaching about wealth in this parable?



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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

1. What happened to the rich man?
 - a. **When he died he went to a place of suffering, he could see Lazarus in comfort but couldn't escape where he was. He wanted to warn his family.**
2. What happened to Lazarus?
 - a. **When he died he was taken to heaven where he was comforted and cared for after suffering during his life.**
3. What might Jesus be teaching about wealth in this parable?
 - a. **Wealth alone doesn't make someone good in God's eyes**
 - b. **People with wealth should help those in need**
 - c. **God cares about how people treat others**
 - d. **People should listen to God's teachings**

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Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

The Prosperity Gospel

Now we've looked at what the Bible says we can look at what the Prosperity Gospel teaches.

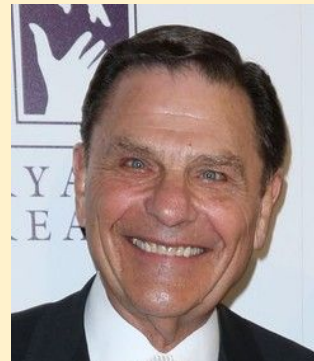
The prosperity gospel is a Christian teaching that God rewards faith, prayer, and generosity with prosperity, such as success, wealth, or good health.

Two examples are Joel Osteen and Kenneth Copeland.



Joel Osteen

A pastor of one of the largest churches in the United States.



Kenneth Copeland

A preacher who teaches the idea of "seed faith". Giving money to church can lead to God blessing believers.

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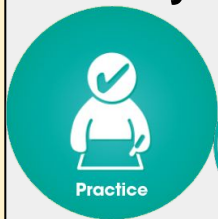


Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

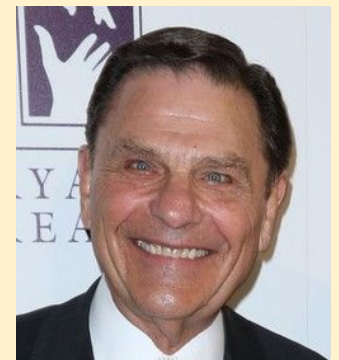
Read one case study each

Then discuss with your partner

1. What do they teach about wealth?
2. Are their teachings more in line with the Old Testament or the teachings of Jesus in the New Testament?



Joel Osteen Who he is: - Joel Osteen is the pastor of Lakewood Church in Houston, Texas, which is one of the largest churches in the United States. What he preaches: - He teaches that God wants people to live full and successful lives. His sermons often focus on faith, hope, positive thinking, and trusting God. He emphasizes that God can bring success, health, and happiness into people's lives. Why he preaches this: - Osteen believes that faith should change every part of a believer's life, and that God wants people to thrive. He focuses on inspiring and motivating people to live positively and trust God in difficult times. Why some people agree: - Supporters like his teaching because it encourages hope, resilience, and action. It makes faith feel practical and relevant to everyday life. Why some people disagree: - Critics say that Osteen's message ignores the struggles of poor or disadvantaged people, and that it can make wealth seem like a guarantee of God's favour, which is not what all Christians believe.	Kenneth Copeland Who he is: - Kenneth Copeland is an American televangelist who is well-known for teaching the "prosperity gospel". He has a large following in the United States. What he preaches: - He teaches a concept called "seed faith", which means that giving money to the church or ministry can bring blessings from God in return. He also teaches that faith and prayer can lead to health, success, and wealth. Why he preaches this: - Copeland believes that God wants believers to prosper materially as well as spiritually, and that wealth can be used to help others and expand God's work. Why some people agree: - Supporters say that his teachings encourage generosity, confidence, and trust in God, and that being prosperous allows believers to do more good in the world. Why some people disagree: - Critics argue that his teaching can exploit vulnerable people, suggesting that poor people are somehow failing in faith. Some also believe it focuses too much on money and not enough on spiritual values.
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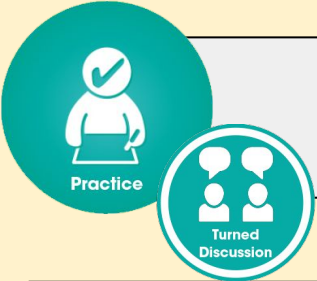


Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

1. What do they teach about wealth?
 - a. **Joel Osteen teaches that God wants people to live full, successful, and happy lives. He focuses on faith, hope, positive thinking, and trusting God, and emphasizes that God can bring success, health, and happiness.**
 - b. **Kenneth Copeland teaches that faith, prayer, and giving money to the church can bring God's blessings, including health, success, and wealth. He also believes that wealth can be used to help others and expand God's work.**
2. Are their teachings more in line with the Old Testament or the teachings of Jesus in the New Testament?
 - a. **Both preachers focus on wealth and success as signs of God's blessing, which is more similar to Old Testament examples.**
 - b. **Both differ from Jesus' teachings in the New Testament, which often warn against greed and emphasize spiritual values over material wealth.**

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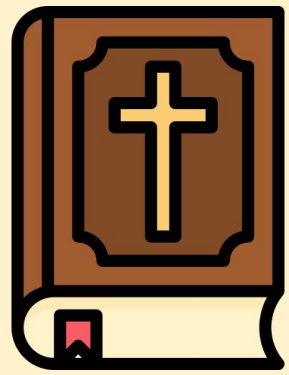
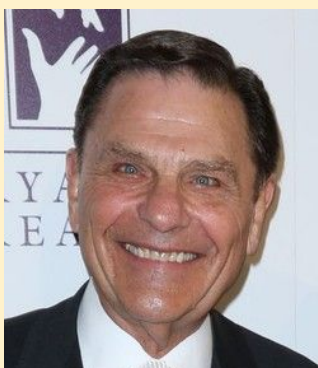


Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Draw the table in your books and with your team discuss why some Christians may support or oppose the prosperity gospel. Record your ideas and be ready to feedback.



Some may support the prosperity Gospel because	Some may oppose the prosperity gospel because





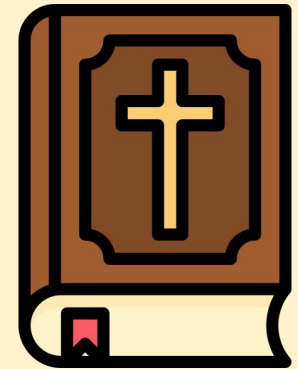
Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

Some may support the prosperity Gospel because

- Some biblical figures were wealthy
- God may bless faithfulness with wealth
- Wealth can be used to help others
- Success may show God's favour
- They believe faith and prayer can positively change lives
- Wealth can be used to support God's work
- It gives hope, motivation and encouragement
- It can may faith fel practical and relevant to everyday life

Some may oppose the prosperity gospel because

- Jesus warned about the dangers of wealth
- Faith should not guarantee success
- It may pressure poor believers to give money when they can't
- Jesus lived a simple life
- It focuses too much on material success rather than spiritual values
- It can seem unrealistic or unfair, especially for those who have faith but are suffering
- It makes helping those in need a secondary consideration



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Practice

Why is the Prosperity Gospel controversial?

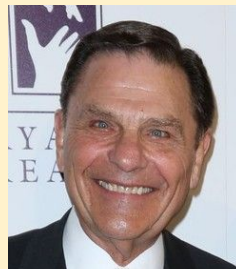
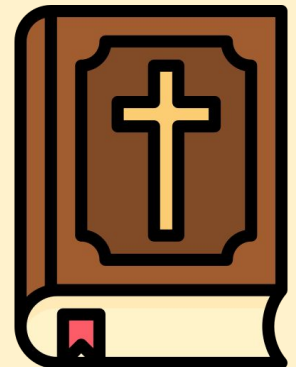
Let's return to the lesson question

Why is the prosperity gospel controversial?

Include reasons for both sides of the debate, make sure you include reference to the Bible in your answer and also give an example of a prosperity gospel preacher.

The prosperity gospel is controversial because...

Controversial;
something that people
disagree about.



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